'Break contact. Cover each other while you do so and get away. I will meet you at the Maulvi's house in Shera village as soon as you all reach there. Ensure no one is left behind,' yelled the leader before slinking away with his bodyguards to the 'getaway car' parked in a lane nearby.

'Yeh saala Shaitan Singh is waqt bhi haath se nikal gaya hai. Allah hi usko bacha raha hai' (this b——d has gotten away this time too. Allah seems to be saving him), said the leader to his mentors on the walkie talkie. The firing continued in spurts for a while, as the terrorists thinned out and disappeared into the alleys of the old town.

The diagrammatic plan of the elaborately conceived urban ambush to eliminate me was recovered by chance from the person of an apprehended terrorist named Nissar some days later (see Sketches 13.1 and 13.2).

The detailed planning that the terrorist group had carried out is evident from the sketch. The reverse side of the hand-drawn plan had the names of the terrorists, their locations and tasks. In all there were about twenty terrorists who took part in this ambush.

Quickly, Suresh regained control of the group, and it was then that he realized that the last vehicle of the convoy was nowhere to be seen. It had got detached from the rest in a deliberate blocking action by a truck that appeared from the opposite direction. However, the leader of the rear protection party, a thorough professional, did not play into the terrorists' hands. He wisely deployed the men at the far end of the ambush site, and did not blunder into the killing zone. Had they tried to join up with the rest of us, none of them would have survived the murderous onslaught.

It was a deliberate strategy of the terrorists to execute this action in the marketplace so that the blame for the civilian casualties and other collateral damage could be attributed to the army. They could always count on the support of their overground workers and the local media. In the race for sensational 'breaking news', some reporters were ready to look the other way.